

MANAGERS

Why 1:1 Meetings Matter

1:1 meetings are crucial for several reasons:

- Building Relationships: They help build strong, trusting relationships between managers and staff members, which is essential for a positive work environment.
- Providing Feedback: These meetings offer a platform for continuous, two-way feedback, helping both parties understand each other's perspectives and improve performance.
- Addressing Concerns: They allow employees to voice concerns, discuss challenges, and seek guidance in a safe and supportive setting.
- Fostering Development: Managers can use this time to discuss career aspirations, identify development opportunities, and support their employees' growth

FEEDBACK

Summarize progress, strengths, events, and accomplishments:

- Recognize good performance
- Include progress toward goals
- Mention strengths exemplified by actions throughout the quarter
- Discuss events the employee was a part of or organized
- Review what was done and accomplished
- Describe recent education and training completed
- Include special assignments and projects as well as participation in task forces and committees
- Include outcomes and results with numerical data when applicable
- Indicate areas where good performance can be elevated or where improvement is needed: Indicate areas in which potential development is possible
- Highlight techniques or processes where improvement is needed
- Note areas of overall performance that may be deficient
- Clarify expectations for acceptable behavior

Identify goals, career/skill development, and growth opportunities:

- Provide an action plan and/or resources to help the employee improve
- Discuss potential training, conferences, and development resources o Set reasonable goals to work toward during the next quarter
- Create growth opportunities to focus on during the next quarter, such as:

- Taking part in meetings on specific topics
- Performing duties that expand knowledge of and role in the department
- Identify professional development opportunities
- Recommend coaching or mentoring supports

Setting Goals

Establishing goals and objectives makes it clear what a leader expects of an employee. It also develops the employee and advances the organization. The goals should be challenging yet relevant to the work of the employee. To create performance based goals, consider using the SMART goal criteria:

Specific- Make them as specific as possible.

Measurable- What will success look like?

Aggressive and Achievable- Give them room to stretch and grow.

Relevant- Make sure they focus on outcomes that matter most.

Time-bound- When will progress be discussed?

Helpful Hints

Refrain from statements of beliefs and philosophies

Use specific examples, but not the same ones repeatedly (consider the entire quarter)

Provide context

- Describe the climate or environment surrounding the situation, problem, or goal
- Use clear, direct language

Avoid Major Evaluator Errors

- The Halo/Pitchfork Effect. Allowing one good deed or bad incident to color the entire Check-in
- The Recency Effect. Failing to assess performance for an entire quarter and focusing only on the past few weeks
- Compatibility. Using friendship or lack of friendship to affect the content in the Check-in
- The Central Tendency. Writing all Check-ins in a similar fashion

Throughout the Quarter

Providing continuous performance feedback to employees is a leadership imperative. Nothing on the Check-in should be a surprise—rather it should be a way to summarize the feedback provided all along in a more formal way.

Avoiding the Status Meeting Trap

To ensure 1:1 meetings are productive and meaningful, it's important to steer clear of turning them into status updates. Here are some tips to keep your 1:1s focused on what truly matters:

- Prepare Thoughtful Agendas: Create agendas that include topics beyond daily tasks, such as career goals, skill development, and personal interests.
- Ask Open-Ended Questions: Encourage deeper conversations by asking questions that prompt reflection and discussion, rather than yes/no answers.
- Balance the Conversation: Ensure the meeting is a two-way dialogue, where both the manager and the employee have the opportunity to share and listen.
- Follow Up on Action Items: While it's important to address ongoing projects, make sure to also follow up on personal and professional development goals discussed in previous meetings.

By focusing on these elements, 1:1 meetings can become a powerful tool for enhancing employee engagement, satisfaction, and performance.

Remember that 1:1 meetings are bi-directional and they should be dialogues and conversations. Productive 1:1 meetings and check-ins take practice and intention to work well both parties involved.

QUESTIONS A MANAGER CAN ASK STAFF MEMBER

Growth and development

- What are some of the work projects you're most proud of, and what do you think you might want to do next?
- What has been the work highlight/lowlight from the past week?
- What are your work and non-work highlights of the past month?
- Who's someone in the organization that you'd like to learn more from?
- What professional goals would you like to accomplish in the next quarter, 6 to 12 months, and what makes you say that?
- If you had 10% of your time to do a passion project at work, what would it be?
- Is your job what you expected when you accepted it? If not, where has it differed

- What other roles here could you see yourself in down the line? Or what areas would you like to explore? What else can I be doing to help progress your career?
- What's one thing you'd like to do more of, outside of work this coming month?
- Imagine it's two years from now, and things have gone well: What has been your role in that? What does your role look like?

Communication and feedback

- What's one thing we can do to improve the performance of the team?
- Are you happy with our level of communication? How would you change it?
- What's top of mind right now that we haven't talked about yet?
- If you were managing the team, what would you do differently?
- Who is doing a great job on the team? What have they done?
- Am I acting like the best manager you could wish for? What could I be doing better?
 - When's the best time to give feedback on your work?
- Where has our communication faltered? Can you give me an example?
- Am I providing enough clarity on our direction?
- Where would you like me involved more or less in your day to day?
- What do you like about our one-on-one meetings? What can be improved?
- Are there any roles on the team that you feel unclear on?
- What are your top priorities this week?
- What's a problem we have on our team that I might not know about?
- What can I hold you accountable for next time we talk?
- How could we improve cross-functional collaboration at?

Job satisfaction and motivation

- How are you feeling about your role?
- Do you feel like you're growing in your role? Tell me why/why not.
- What interests you about the project(s) you're currently working on, and why?
- What is your favorite/least favorite thing about your work right now?
- What's one thing we could change about work for you that would improve your personal life?
- What's something you're proud of that happened this week? This month? This quarter?
- What are you passionate about, personally or professionally?
- What makes you excited and motivated to work on a project?
- Do you feel adequately supported by other team members? What makes you say that?

- What's one thing you would recommend to improve our workplace culture?
- Do you find your physical work environment productive? Is there anything preventing you from being productive?
- How do you feel your work/life balance is? What would you want to change, if anything?
- Are there any goals we have on a organizational, division, team or individual level that you feel are entirely unattainable? If so, why?
- What's the best thing about working here?

The 12-month feedback cycle is as follows.

Monitoring & Observing Performance	Conduct & Document Check-ins By
<i>The manager will monitor and observe performance during these months.</i>	<i>The manager to hold the check-in meetings and document them by...</i>
January – March	End of April
April – June	End of July
July – September	End of October
October – December	End of January

SOURCES:

“Making the Most of Quarterly Check-Ins” <https://leadership.hr.ufl.edu/toolkit/> University of Florida

“Performance Accountability & Feedback” Dept of Administrative Services oregon.gov
<https://www.topicflow.com/template/72>

“The Importance of Meetings/Check Ins” Northwestern University

Timeline

August 2026 – launch & goal setting for the remainder of 2026; pilot process to identify any changes to be made

October 2026 – check-In; progress on goals, will have a couple of months to continue work on goals

January 2027 – process officially begins; annual reflection of 2026 & goal setting for 2027

April 2027 – Q1 check-in

July 2027 – Q2 check-in & midyear review

October 2027 – Q3 check-in